

came on at the Marang Gomke Jaipal Singh Astro Turf Hockey Stadium in the heart of Ranchi, the teething troubles were soon relegated to distant memories. Riveting end-to-end action over 13 matchdays culminated in Neha Goyal's Odisha Warriors lifting the glitzy trophy.

The pitch was a major talking point throughout the tournament, with India men's coach Craig Fulton, Team Gonasika captain Manpreet Singh, and Toofans' Gonzalo Peillat, among many others, claiming that the Ranchi turf was excessively 'bumpy,' which made trapping the ball difficult during penalty corners.

"The surface is pretty much new, so it will take some time to become more stable. At the moment, it is very bumpy, and there were mistakes in the receptions. Maybe in one to two years, it will be perfect," Peillat told *Sportstar*.

Looking back at the tournament, it seems that Hockey India's best decision was to forgo the revenue it would have generated from ticket sales by offering free entry for both the men's and women's competitions. The RSVPing process, although online, also ran smoothly.

Jharkhand, arguably home to some of the most knowledgeable hockey fans in the country after Odisha, responded enthusiastically to the offer, filling the stands in team jerseys even on weekdays. A special mention must go to the DJ, who did a fantastic job of hyping the mood with peppy Nagpuri (not to be confused with the city in Maharashtra) tracks. However, there were a few questionable song choices, with misogynistic lyrics being blasted through speakers while introducing the all-women lineups.

What further helped attract a capacity crowd was a largely successful advertising campaign. The message was widely propagated through newspapers, social media channels, and massive flex banners around the city. The decision to provide information in the local language also helped engage the audience.

Paid premium seating could have



been introduced as a lucrative add-on, with perks such as a dinner buffet, the opportunity to interact with stars, and chances to win signed merchandise.

Franchises could also take a cue from the Indian Premier League (IPL) by organising meet-and-greet events in key city hubs, like Nucleus Mall on Circular Road or the Ranchi Market, just a stone's throw from where two of the four teams were based.

One recurring opinion among players and coaches alike was the challenge of coping with a cramped

Future star: Sonam from JSW Soorma Hockey Club received the trophy and cheque for Upcoming Player of the Tournament. SHASHISHEKAR KASHYAP

calendar. The round trip to Rourkela, where each team played once, only added to the woes.

"It has become very difficult for us. We wake up, hit the gym, have breakfast, attend a team meeting, warm up, and barely have time for lunch before heading to the stadium. In the midst of all that, there are

« The recently concluded edition served as a dry run for the FIH Pro League, which kicks off on February 15 »